Ichigo Closed Beta Readiness Report

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1. Executive Summary

> **Decision:** Ichigo is ready for a controlled closed beta.
>
> **Decision not to take yet:** Ichigo is not ready for a broad public launch.

Ichigo has moved from concept into a working full-stack product. The core thesis is now live in the application itself: a post is not just content, it is content plus context. Users can choose the kind of reply they want, responders can see that ask, and the product now tries to enforce the social contract through fit checking, rewrite guidance, cooldowns, moderation, and relationship controls.

The product is strong enough to test with real target users in a limited environment. It is not yet strong enough for open distribution, broad abuse exposure, or production-scale operational risk.

2. Current Product Stage

Best label today: late alpha / closed beta candidate.

Not yet: public MVP, general social network, or market-proven feedback platform.

This stage means the product can now answer behavioral questions with real users, but still needs controlled conditions and close operator attention.

3. What Is Already Real

- Full-stack `Next.js` application with real backend routes and persistent storage.
- Email/password auth and Google sign-in.
- SMTP-backed email delivery.
- Verification-code flow with 6-digit codes, 30-minute expiry, and invalidation on resend.
- Password reset, recovery, session management, and session revocation.
- Onboarding before full app access.
- Feed, compose, thread, rooms, profile, notifications, settings, and moderation routes.
- Visible response modes and ask-preserving thread views.
- Heuristic fit checking, rewrite guidance, cooldown consequences, and optional Gemini second pass.
- Block, mute, unmute, unblock, report, and comment deletion flows.
- Automated tests covering security, repository logic, mode alignment, and HTTP flows.

4. Closed Beta Positioning

Ichigo should currently be positioned as:

- a context-first feedback product
- for founders, builders, and a narrow slice of creators
- best suited for work, decisions, drafts, launches, dilemmas, and sensitive feedback moments

Ichigo should not currently be positioned as:

- a general-purpose social network
- a broad Twitter/Reddit/LinkedIn substitute
- a product for every kind of posting and every kind of audience

5. Why Closed Beta Is The Right Next Step

The product now has a usable core loop, but the main question is still behavioral: do explicit response modes actually produce better replies and stronger return behavior for the target wedge?

A closed beta is the right environment to answer that because it lets the team:

- observe whether the idea is understood quickly
- watch whether users post without much friction
- evaluate whether replies feel meaningfully better
- review moderation patterns manually
- fix rough edges without public-launch pressure

6. What Is Good Enough For Closed Beta

6.1 Core Loop

Users can sign up, verify, onboard, post, reply, and experience the basic Ichigo promise: choose the response context first, then receive replies shaped by that ask.

6.2 Authentication

The authentication stack is good enough for controlled beta. It includes verification, recovery, stronger password rules, and real email delivery.

6.3 Fit Checking

Fit checking is good enough to test, but should still be treated as experimental. The product now has enough structure to learn whether the feature helps or frustrates users.

6.4 Trust And Moderation

The current trust layer is sufficient for a small, selected cohort. It is not yet sufficient for the open internet.

6.5 UX

The app is now a multi-page product with materially improved navigation, theming, validation, feedback states, and responsive behavior. It is good enough for careful beta users, though not yet fully polished.

7. Known Weaknesses To Accept During Beta

- Fit checking is still partly heuristic and will produce false positives and false negatives.
- Some flows still need UX tightening, especially under unusual or slower usage patterns.
- Moderation still depends heavily on manual review.
- Infrastructure is still local-first rather than production-hardened.
- Cross-device QA has improved, but is not yet fully systematic.

8. Public MVP Blockers

Ichigo should not move to a public launch until these blockers are addressed:

- Stronger abuse-resistant moderation and admin tooling.
- Anti-spam and anti-bot protections suitable for open distribution.
- Managed production infrastructure, especially database, logging, monitoring, and backups.
- Clear privacy, data, and age-policy decisions.
- Better measurement of activation, reply quality, and retention from real users.
- More evidence that the wedge is correct and the product creates repeat usage.

9. What The Closed Beta Must Prove

1. Users understand the product without long explanation.
2. Users create posts in the target wedge.
3. Replies improve because the ask is visible.
4. Posters feel the difference and come back.
5. The target wedge is correct.
6. Fit checking helps more than it annoys.

10. Core Metrics To Watch

- Signup completion rate
- Email verification completion rate
- Onboarding completion rate
- First post creation rate
- Replies per post

- Time to first reply
- Average fit score
- Rewrite acceptance rate
- Return rate after receiving a reply
- Day 1 and Day 7 retention
- Report rate, mute/block rate, and low-fit reply rate

11. Recommended First Cohort

The first users should be selected, not random.

- Founders and indie hackers
- Builders and technical creators
- Designers and product-minded students
- People who already ask for honest feedback online

The first cohort should be small enough to observe directly and large enough to generate genuine feedback loops. A first cohort of 15 to 20 users, followed by an expansion toward 50, is the right shape.

12. 30-Day Closed Beta Plan

Week 1

Prepare invite list, beta rules, onboarding copy, moderation process, and tracking setup.

Week 2

Invite the first 15 to 20 users and focus on onboarding, first posts, first replies, and confusion points.

Week 3

Expand toward 50 users if stable, then evaluate rooms, moderation patterns, and mode usage.

Week 4

Review the evidence and decide whether to continue, expand, narrow, or rework.

13. Final Recommendation

Recommendation: proceed to a controlled closed beta.

Treat the beta as a product-learning phase, not a launch event. The goal is to validate whether explicit response context creates better replies and better return behavior for founders, builders, and selected creators.

Do not move to public MVP until the product proves activation, reply quality, retention, and basic operational resilience.